

A PAIRWISE LEARNING-TO-RANK MODEL FOR FEATURE ENGINEERING, LOGISTIC OBJECTIVES, AND CALIBRATION

IZ TECÚM

ABSTRACT. We develop an interpretable learning-to-rank pipeline for first-round admissions screening in Pi Mu Epsilon, using limited human pairwise comparisons [1, 2, 3] within the pairwise learning-to-rank framework [4, 5, 6, 7]. A deterministic map $x : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow [0, 10]^{21}$ encodes structured fields, resume text, and short-answer signals as bounded named features [8, Chapter 3]. The linear score $s_w(a) := \langle w, x(a) \rangle$ minimizes the regularized logistic risk [5, 8]

$$L_\lambda(w) := \frac{1}{|\mathcal{D}|} \sum_{(i,j,y_{ij}) \in \mathcal{D}} \log(1 + \exp(-z_{ij} \langle w, x(a_i) - x(a_j) \rangle)) + \frac{\lambda}{2} \|w\|_2^2, \quad z_{ij} := 2y_{ij} - 1.$$

For $\lambda > 0$, this objective is λ -strongly convex and $(\lambda + 25 \cdot 21)$ -smooth; hence gradient descent converges linearly to its unique minimizer [9, Chapter 3]. Raw scores are calibrated by

$$\hat{s}(a) := 10 \hat{F}_w(s_w(a)),$$

which maps them to $[0, 10]$, preserves order, and is invariant under strictly increasing reparametrization [7], [8, Chapter 4]. Finally, we specify the reproducible data artifacts `applicants.jsonl`, `pairs.csv`, and `rank_model.json` linking local training to deployed scoring.

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Part 1. Pairwise Ranking

1. INTRODUCTION

First-round admissions screening produces a consistent and auditable ordering that allocates reviewer attention rather than a final decision, and in the regime of $n \approx 10\text{--}50$ applicants per cycle the only reliably collectable supervision is the comparison $a_i \succ a_j$ between two applications [1], [4], [5], [7]. Throughout, $\mathcal{A}$ is the space of applications, $d \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 1}$ the feature dimension, $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ the Euclidean inner product on $\mathbb{R}^d$ with norm $\|\cdot\|_2$, $\mathbf{1}\{\cdot\}$ an indicator, I the identity matrix, $\preceq$ the Loewner order on symmetric matrices, and

$$\sigma(t) := \frac{1}{1 + e^{-t}} \quad (t \in \mathbb{R}), \quad \sigma(-t) = 1 - \sigma(t), \quad \sigma'(t) = \sigma(t) \sigma(-t).$$

1.1. Setting and result.

Definition 1.1.1 (Features, scores, and margins). A feature map is a deterministic function $x: \mathcal{A} \rightarrow [0, 10]^d$, $a \mapsto x(a) = (x_1(a), \dots, x_d(a))$, carrying a schema identifier $\text{fv} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 1}$. For $w \in \mathbb{R}^d$ and applications a, a_i, a_j ,

$$s_w(a) := \langle w, x(a) \rangle = \sum_{k=1}^d w_k x_k(a), \quad d_{ij} := x(a_i) - x(a_j), \quad \Delta_{ij}(w) := s_w(a_i) - s_w(a_j) = \langle w, d_{ij} \rangle.$$

Definition 1.1.2 (Pairwise dataset and regularized pairwise logistic risk, [1, 5]). A pairwise dataset is a finite multiset $\mathcal{D} = \{(i, j, y_{ij})\}$ of pairs of applicant indices with labels $y_{ij} \in \{0, 1\}$, $y_{ij} = 1$ meaning $a_i \succ a_j$, and $z_{ij} := 2y_{ij} - 1 \in \{-1, +1\}$. The Bradley–Terry probability, the pairwise logistic loss, and the ℓ_2 -regularized risk are

$$\mathbb{P}(a_i \succ a_j \mid w) := \sigma(\Delta_{ij}(w)), \quad \ell_{ij}(w) := \log(1 + \exp(-z_{ij} \Delta_{ij}(w))),$$

$$L_\lambda(w) := \frac{1}{|\mathcal{D}|} \sum_{(i,j,y) \in \mathcal{D}} \ell_{ij}(w) + \frac{\lambda}{2} \|w\|_2^2 \quad (\lambda \geq 0), \quad \Lambda := \lambda + \frac{1}{4|\mathcal{D}|} \sum_{(i,j,y) \in \mathcal{D}} \|d_{ij}\|_2^2.$$

Theorem A (Regularized pairwise logistic ranking). *Let $x: \mathcal{A} \rightarrow [0, 10]^d$ be a feature map, $\mathcal{D}$ a pairwise dataset, $\lambda > 0$, $w^{(t+1)} := w^{(t)} - \Lambda^{-1} \nabla L_\lambda(w^{(t)})$, and $\hat{s}$ the calibrated score of Definition 6.1.1 on a pool $\mathcal{P}$. Then L_λ has a unique minimizer w_λ , $\Lambda \leq \lambda + 25d$, and for all $w \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $t \geq 0$, and $a, b \in \mathcal{P}$,*

$$\lambda I \preceq \nabla^2 L_\lambda(w) \preceq \Lambda I, \quad s_w(a) \leq s_w(b) \iff \hat{s}(a) \leq \hat{s}(b),$$

$$L_\lambda(w^{(t)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda) \leq \left(1 - \frac{\lambda}{\Lambda}\right)^t (L_\lambda(w^{(0)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda)).$$

Proof. §7 □

2. PRELIMINARIES

2.1. Ranking models, the logistic function, and linear bounds.

Definition 2.1.1 (Bradley–Terry and Plackett–Luce models, [1, 2, 3]). For $\theta \in \mathbb{R}^n$ and a permutation π of $\{1, \dots, n\}$,

$$\mathbb{P}_\theta(i \succ j) := \frac{e^{\theta_i}}{e^{\theta_i} + e^{\theta_j}} = \sigma(\theta_i - \theta_j), \quad \mathbb{P}_\theta(\pi) := \prod_{k=1}^n \frac{e^{\theta_{\pi(k)}}}{\sum_{l=k}^n e^{\theta_{\pi(l)}}},$$

the second reducing to the first for $n = 2$.

Fact 2.1.2 (Logistic identities, [8]). *For $t \in \mathbb{R}$,*

$$\sigma(-t) = 1 - \sigma(t), \quad \sigma'(t) = \sigma(t) \sigma(-t) \in (0, \tfrac{1}{4}], \quad -\log \sigma(t) = \log(1 + e^{-t}),$$

$$\frac{d}{dt} \log(1 + e^t) = \sigma(t), \quad \frac{d^2}{dt^2} \log(1 + e^t) = \sigma'(t) > 0, \quad \frac{d^2}{dt^2} \log(1 + e^{-t}) = \sigma'(-t) > 0.$$

Lemma 2.1.3 (Linear functionals on a box). *For $w, v \in \mathbb{R}^d$ with $\|v\|_\infty \leq 10$,*

$$|\langle w, v \rangle| \leq \|w\|_1 \|v\|_\infty \leq 10 \|w\|_1, \quad \|v\|_2^2 \leq d \|v\|_\infty^2 \leq 100d, \quad v, w \in [0, \infty)^d \implies 0 \leq \langle w, v \rangle \leq 10 \|w\|_1.$$

Proof.

$$|\langle w, v \rangle| \leq \sum_{k=1}^d |w_k| |v_k| \leq \|v\|_\infty \|w\|_1, \quad \|v\|_2^2 = \sum_{k=1}^d v_k^2 \leq d \|v\|_\infty^2, \quad v_k, w_k \geq 0 \implies 0 \leq \langle w, v \rangle \leq 10 \|w\|_1.$$

□

Lemma 2.1.4 (Level sets of a linear functional). *For $w \in \mathbb{R}^d \setminus \{0\}$, $\hat{w} := w/\|w\|_2$, $w^\perp := \{\eta : \langle w, \eta \rangle = 0\}$, and $c, c' \in \mathbb{R}$,*

$$H_w(c) := \{\xi \in \mathbb{R}^d : \langle w, \xi \rangle = c\} = \frac{c}{\|w\|_2^2} \hat{w} + w^\perp, \quad \text{dist}(H_w(c), H_w(c')) = \frac{|c - c'|}{\|w\|_2}.$$

Proof.

$$\langle w, \xi \rangle = c \iff \xi - \frac{c}{\|w\|_2^2} \hat{w} \in w^\perp, \quad \xi \in H_w(c), \eta \in H_w(c') \implies \|\xi - \eta\|_2 \geq |\langle \hat{w}, \xi - \eta \rangle| = \frac{|c - c'|}{\|w\|_2},$$

$$\eta := \xi + \frac{c' - c}{\|w\|_2^2} \hat{w} \in H_w(c') \implies \|\xi - \eta\|_2 = \frac{|c - c'|}{\|w\|_2}.$$

□

Remark 2.1.5 (Linear Bradley–Terry models). Definition 1.1.2 is Definition 2.1.1 with $\theta_i = s_w(a_i)$, and Bradley–Terry on n items is the case $d = n$, $x(a_i) = e_i$, $w = \theta$,

$$\mathbb{P}(a_i \succ a_j | w) = \sigma(s_w(a_i) - s_w(a_j)) = \mathbb{P}_{(s_w(a_m))_m} (i \succ j), \quad x(a_i) = e_i \implies \Delta_{ij}(w) = w_i - w_j.$$

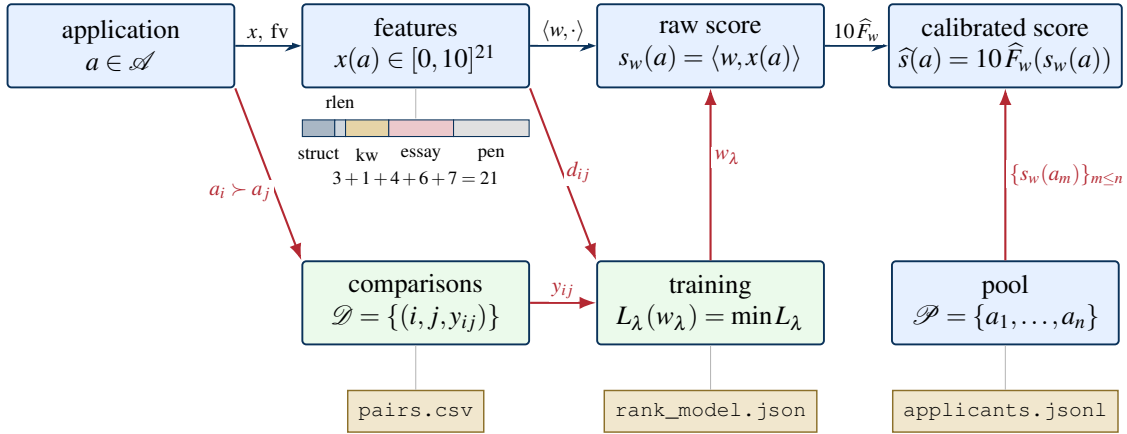


FIGURE 1. The pipeline. Applications are mapped deterministically to 21 bounded coordinates in five blocks, scored linearly, and calibrated against the pool, while human comparisons and feature differences train w_λ ; the three files record labels, weights, and pool records.

3. FROM APPLICATIONS TO VECTORS

Every coordinate of the feature map is a bounded deterministic functional of one signal, so all randomness enters through the training of § 5 and none through extraction [5], [8, Chapter 3]. Throughout, Σ^* is the set of finite strings, $v \sqsubseteq T$ means that the phrase v occurs in T , $d = 21$, and an application a

carries its grade point average, calculus completion, entered course codes, browser-extracted resume text, and two short answers,

$$\text{GPA}(a) \in [0, 4.33], \quad \text{Calc}(a) \in \{\text{yes}, \text{no}\}, \quad U(a) \subset \Sigma^*, \quad T(a), E_A(a), E_B(a) \in \Sigma^*.$$

3.1. The five feature blocks.

Definition 3.1.1 (Feature map and schema). The deterministic feature map $x : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow [0, 10]^{21}$ with schema identifier $\text{fv} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 1}$ concatenates the five blocks of Definitions 3.1.2–3.1.7,

$$x(a) = (x_{\text{struct}}(a), x_{\text{resume}}(a), x_{\text{kw}}(a), x_{\text{essay}}(a), x_{\text{pen}}(a)) \in [0, 10]^3 \times [0, 10]^1 \times [0, 10]^4 \times [0, 10]^6 \times \{0, 10\}^7.$$

Definition 3.1.2 (Structured coordinates). For a whitelist $\mathcal{W}$ of course codes, the graduate codes $\mathcal{G}$ of the form MATH GR5xxx and MATH GR6xxx, and nondecreasing $\phi, \psi : [0, 1] \rightarrow [0, 1]$, for instance $\phi(u) = u^\alpha$ with $\alpha \in (0, 1]$,

$$\begin{aligned} C(a) &:= U(a) \cap (\mathcal{W} \cup \mathcal{G}), \quad |C(a)| \leq 6, \quad x_{\text{gpa}}(a) := 10\phi\left(\frac{\text{GPA}(a)}{4.33}\right), \quad x_{\text{upper}}(a) := 10\psi\left(\frac{|C(a)|}{6}\right), \\ x_{\text{calc}}(a) &:= 10 \cdot \mathbf{1}\{\text{Calc}(a) = \text{yes}\}, \quad x_{\text{struct}}(a) := (x_{\text{gpa}}, x_{\text{calc}}, x_{\text{upper}})(a) \in [0, 10] \times \{0, 10\} \times [0, 10]. \end{aligned}$$

Definition 3.1.3 (Resume length coordinate). For $\ell(a) := |T(a)|$, $L_0 > 0$, and nondecreasing $s : [0, \infty) \rightarrow [0, 1]$ with $s(0) = 0$, such as $\min\{1, u\}$ or $1 - e^{-u}$,

$$x_{\text{resume}}(a) := x_{\text{rlen}}(a) := 10s\left(\frac{\ell(a)}{L_0}\right) \in [0, 10], \quad \ell(a) = 0 \implies x_{\text{rlen}}(a) = 0.$$

Definition 3.1.4 (Keyword coordinates). For $\mathcal{K} := \{\text{research}, \text{teach}, \text{leader}, \text{awards}\}$ and, for each $c \in \mathcal{K}$, a finite dictionary $D_c \subset \Sigma^*$ and a threshold $\tau_c \geq 1$,

$$\begin{aligned} N_c(a) &:= \sum_{v \in D_c} \mathbf{1}\{v \sqsubseteq T(a)\}, \quad x_c(a) := 10 \min\left\{1, \frac{N_c(a)}{\tau_c}\right\} \quad \left(\text{or } 10(1 - e^{-N_c(a)/\tau_c})\right), \\ x_{\text{kw}}(a) &:= (x_c(a))_{c \in \mathcal{K}} \in [0, 10]^4, \quad \text{KW}(a) := \frac{1}{4} \sum_{c \in \mathcal{K}} x_c(a) \in [0, 10]. \end{aligned}$$

Example 3.1.5 (Keyword saturation). For $\tau_{\text{research}} = 3$, $v := N_{\text{research}}$, $\chi := x_{\text{research}}$, and resumes containing exactly REU, preprint, poster, or only REU,

$$v(a) = 3 \implies \chi(a) = 10, \quad v(a) = 1 \implies \chi(a) = \frac{10}{3}, \quad v(a) \geq 3 \implies \chi(a) = 10.$$

Definition 3.1.6 (Essay coordinates). For word and sentence counts $\text{wc}, \text{sent} : \Sigma^* \rightarrow \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}$, word bounds $m \leq M$, reflection cues $R \subset \Sigma^*$ (realized, learned, mistake, revised, iterated, feedback, persist), action tokens $P \subset \Sigma^*$ (talk, problem session, reading group, outreach, workshop), a mathematical lexicon $\mathcal{M} \subset \Sigma^*$, thresholds $\rho, \varpi, \mu \geq 1$, and $\bullet \in \{A, B\}$,

$$\begin{aligned} x_{\text{band}, \bullet}(a) &:= 10 \cdot \mathbf{1}\{2 \leq \text{sent}(E_\bullet(a)) \leq 4\} \quad \text{or} \quad x_{\text{band}, \bullet}(a) := 10 \cdot \mathbf{1}\{m \leq \text{wc}(E_\bullet(a)) \leq M\}, \\ x_{\text{arc}}(a) &:= 10 \min\left\{1, \frac{1}{\rho} \sum_{v \in R} \mathbf{1}\{v \sqsubseteq E_A(a)\}\right\}, \quad x_{\text{plan}}(a) := 10 \min\left\{1, \frac{1}{\varpi} \sum_{v \in P} \mathbf{1}\{v \sqsubseteq E_B(a)\}\right\}, \\ x_{\text{math}, \bullet}(a) &:= 10 \min\left\{1, \frac{1}{\mu} \sum_{v \in \mathcal{M}} \mathbf{1}\{v \sqsubseteq E_\bullet(a)\}\right\}, \\ x_{\text{essay}}(a) &:= (x_{\text{band}, A}, x_{\text{band}, B}, x_{\text{arc}}, x_{\text{plan}}, x_{\text{math}, A}, x_{\text{math}, B})(a) \in [0, 10]^6. \end{aligned}$$

Definition 3.1.7 (Penalty block). The block $x_{\text{pen}}(a) \in \{0, 10\}^7$ lists the indicators $10 \cdot \mathbf{1}\{\text{check fails}\}$ of seven validation checks, the sign of each influence on the rank being left to the learned weight.

Example 3.1.8 (Essay decomposition). For a_1, a_2 agreeing in every coordinate except x_{plan} , with $E_B(a_1)$ naming at least ϖ actions of P and $E_B(a_2)$ none,

$$x_{\text{plan}}(a_1) = 10, \quad x_{\text{plan}}(a_2) = 0, \quad \Delta_{12}(w) = \langle w, d_{12} \rangle = 10 w_{\text{plan}}, \quad \mathbb{P}(a_1 \succ a_2 \mid w) = \sigma(10 w_{\text{plan}}).$$

Proposition 3.1.9 (Boundedness and sensitivity of the feature map). For $a, b \in \mathcal{A}$, $w \in \mathbb{R}^d$, $c \in \mathcal{H}$, and $x'_c(a)$ the keyword coordinate after inserting one phrase into $T(a)$,

$$\|x(a)\|_\infty \leq 10, \quad \|x(a) - x(b)\|_2^2 \leq 100d, \quad |s_w(a) - s_w(b)| \leq 10\|w\|_1, \quad 0 \leq x'_c(a) - x_c(a) \leq \frac{10}{\tau_c},$$

the last for both saturations of Definition 3.1.4.

Proof.

$$x(a), x(b) \in [0, 10]^d \implies \|d_{ab}\|_\infty \leq 10 \xrightarrow{2.1.3} \|d_{ab}\|_2^2 \leq 100d, \quad |s_w(a) - s_w(b)| = |\langle w, d_{ab} \rangle| \leq 10\|w\|_1,$$

$$N_c(a) \leq N'_c(a) \leq N_c(a) + 1 \implies 0 \leq \min\left\{1, \frac{N'_c(a)}{\tau_c}\right\} - \min\left\{1, \frac{N_c(a)}{\tau_c}\right\} \leq \frac{1}{\tau_c},$$

$$0 \leq e^{-N_c(a)/\tau_c} - e^{-N'_c(a)/\tau_c} \leq 1 - e^{-1/\tau_c} \leq \frac{1}{\tau_c}.$$

□

4. LINEAR SCORING MODEL

The score is linear so that each weight is the marginal effect of one named signal, and its geometry is that of projection onto $\hat{w} := w/\|w\|_2$ [5], [8, Chapter 3]. Throughout, $\xi \in \mathbb{R}^d$ denotes a feature vector and $H_w(c)$ the level sets of Lemma 2.1.4.

4.1. Scores, level sets, and scale.

Definition 4.1.1 (Score geometry). For $w \in \mathbb{R}^d \setminus \{0\}$ and applications a, b ,

$$s_w(a) = \|w\|_2 \langle \hat{w}, x(a) \rangle, \quad x(a) \in H_w(s_w(a)), \quad \text{dist}(H_w(s_w(a)), H_w(s_w(b))) \xrightarrow{2.1.4} \frac{|\Delta_{ab}(w)|}{\|w\|_2},$$

so $x(a)$ and $x(b)$ lie on parallel hyperplanes whose separation along $\hat{w}$ is the margin divided by $\|w\|_2$.

Proposition 4.1.2 (Scale and order). For $w \in \mathbb{R}^d \setminus \{0\}$, $c > 0$, and applications a, b ,

$$s_{cw} = c s_w, \quad \Delta_{ab}(cw) = c \Delta_{ab}(w), \quad s_w(a) < s_w(b) \iff s_{cw}(a) < s_{cw}(b) \iff \langle \hat{w}, x(a) \rangle < \langle \hat{w}, x(b) \rangle,$$

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial \xi_k} \langle w, \xi \rangle = w_k, \quad w \in [0, \infty)^d \implies 0 \leq s_w(a) \leq 10\|w\|_1,$$

so the ordering depends on $\hat{w}$ alone while the probabilities $\sigma(\Delta_{ab}(w))$ depend on $\|w\|_2$ as well.

Proof.

$$s_{cw}(a) = \langle cw, x(a) \rangle = c s_w(a) \implies \Delta_{ab}(cw) = c \Delta_{ab}(w), \quad c > 0 \implies s_w(a) < s_w(b) \iff s_{cw}(a) < s_{cw}(b),$$

$$c := \|w\|_2^{-1} \implies s_{cw}(a) = \langle \hat{w}, x(a) \rangle, \quad \frac{\partial}{\partial \xi_k} \sum_{l=1}^d w_l \xi_l = w_k \xrightarrow{2.1.3} 0 \leq s_w(a) \leq 10\|w\|_1.$$

□

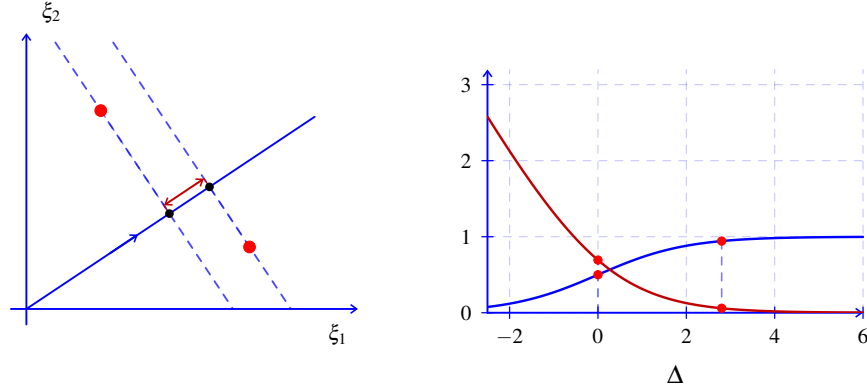


FIGURE 2. For $w = (3, 2)$, $x(a) = (1.2, 3.2)$, and $x(b) = (3.6, 1)$, the left panel shows $H_w(10)$, $H_w(12.8)$, and separation $2.8/\sqrt{13}$; the right plots σ in blue and $\ell(\Delta) = \log(1 + e^{-\Delta})$ in red, with $(\sigma, \ell)(0) = (\frac{1}{2}, \log 2)$ and $(\sigma, \ell)(2.8) \approx (.943, .059)$.

5. PAIRWISE TRAINING OBJECTIVE

Maximum likelihood for the Bradley–Terry probabilities of Definition 1.1.2 is the minimization of a sum of logistic losses of signed margins, whose ℓ_2 -regularized version is strongly convex and smooth with explicit constants, so that gradient descent converges linearly [1], [5], [8, Chapter 4], [9, Chapter 3]. Throughout, $\mathcal{D}$ is a pairwise dataset, $N := |\mathcal{D}|$, sums over (i, j, y) run over $\mathcal{D}$, σ' is evaluated at $\langle w, d_{ij} \rangle$ unless stated otherwise, and $\lambda \geq 0$.

5.1. Loss, gradient, convexity, and gradient descent.

Lemma 5.1.1 (Negative log-likelihood is the logistic loss). *For $(i, j, y) \in \mathcal{D}$, $z = 2y - 1$, and $\Delta = \Delta_{ij}(w)$,*

$$-y \log \sigma(\Delta) - (1 - y) \log(1 - \sigma(\Delta)) = \log(1 + e^{-z\Delta}) = \ell_{ij}(w),$$

$$\frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \ell_{ij}(w) = -\frac{1}{N} \log \prod_{(i,j,y)} \mathbb{P}(a_i \succ a_j \mid w)^y \mathbb{P}(a_j \succ a_i \mid w)^{1-y}.$$

Proof.

$$y = 1 \implies z = 1, \quad -\log \sigma(\Delta) \xrightarrow{2.1.2} \log(1 + e^{-\Delta}) = \log(1 + e^{-z\Delta}),$$

$$y = 0 \implies z = -1, \quad -\log(1 - \sigma(\Delta)) \xrightarrow{2.1.2} -\log \sigma(-\Delta) = \log(1 + e^{\Delta}) = \log(1 + e^{-z\Delta}),$$

$$\mathbb{P}(a_j \succ a_i \mid w) = \sigma(\Delta_{ji}(w)) = \sigma(-\Delta) \xrightarrow{2.1.2} 1 - \sigma(\Delta) \implies -\log(\sigma(\Delta)^y (1 - \sigma(\Delta))^{1-y}) = \ell_{ij}(w).$$

□

Lemma 5.1.2 (Gradient and Hessian). *For $w \in \mathbb{R}^d$,*

$$\nabla \ell_{ij}(w) = (\sigma(\Delta_{ij}(w)) - y_{ij}) d_{ij}, \quad \nabla^2 \ell_{ij}(w) = \sigma'(\Delta_{ij}(w)) d_{ij} \cdot d_{ij}^\top,$$

$$\nabla L_\lambda(w) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} (\sigma(\langle w, d_{ij} \rangle) - y) d_{ij} + \lambda w, \quad \nabla^2 L_\lambda(w) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \sigma'(\langle w, d_{ij} \rangle) d_{ij} \cdot d_{ij}^\top + \lambda I.$$

Proof. Write $\Delta = \langle w, d \rangle$ with $d = d_{ij}$, $y = y_{ij}$, $z = 2y - 1$, and differentiate $\ell_{ij}(w) = \log(1 + e^{-z\Delta})$ by the chain rule.

$$\nabla_w \log(1 + e^{-z\Delta}) = \frac{-ze^{-z\Delta}}{1 + e^{-z\Delta}} d = -z \sigma(-z\Delta) d, \quad \nabla_w \sigma(\langle w, d \rangle) = \sigma'(\Delta) d,$$

$$z = 1 \implies -\sigma(-\Delta)d \stackrel{2.1.2}{\implies} (\sigma(\Delta) - 1)d, \quad z = -1 \implies \sigma(\Delta)d, \quad \nabla \ell_{ij}(w) = (\sigma(\Delta) - y)d,$$

$$\nabla^2 \ell_{ij}(w) = \sigma'(\Delta)d \cdot d^\top, \quad \nabla\left(\frac{\lambda}{2}\|w\|_2^2\right) = \lambda w, \quad \nabla^2\left(\frac{\lambda}{2}\|w\|_2^2\right) = \lambda I.$$

□

Proposition 5.1.3 (Convexity, strong convexity, and smoothness). *For $\lambda \geq 0$, $\Lambda = \lambda + \frac{1}{4N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \|d_{ij}\|_2^2$, and all $w \in \mathbb{R}^d$,*

$$\lambda I \preceq \nabla^2 L_\lambda(w) \preceq \Lambda I \preceq (\lambda + 25d)I, \quad L_\lambda \text{ convex},$$

$$L_\lambda \text{ strictly convex} \iff \lambda > 0 \text{ or } \text{span}\{d_{ij} : (i,j,y) \in \mathcal{D}\} = \mathbb{R}^d,$$

and for $\lambda > 0$ there is a unique minimizer w_λ , characterized by its stationarity equation and bounded by

$$\lambda w_\lambda = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} (y - \sigma(\langle w_\lambda, d_{ij} \rangle)) d_{ij}, \quad \|w_\lambda\|_2 \leq \frac{10\sqrt{d}}{\lambda}.$$

Proof.

$$0 < \sigma' \leq \frac{1}{4} \stackrel{2.1.2, 5.1.2}{\implies} \lambda I \preceq \nabla^2 L_\lambda(w) \preceq \lambda I + \frac{1}{4N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} d_{ij} \cdot d_{ij}^\top \preceq \Lambda I, \quad \|d_{ij}\|_2^2 \stackrel{3.1.9}{\implies} 100d \implies \Lambda \leq \lambda + 25d,$$

$$v^\top \cdot \nabla^2 L_0(w) \cdot v = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \sigma'(\langle w, d_{ij} \rangle) \langle v, d_{ij} \rangle^2 = 0 \iff \langle v, d_{ij} \rangle = 0 \quad \forall (i,j,y) \in \mathcal{D} \iff v \perp \text{span}\{d_{ij}\},$$

$$\lambda > 0 \implies L_\lambda(w) \geq \frac{\lambda}{2} \|w\|_2^2 \longrightarrow \infty \quad (\|w\|_2 \rightarrow \infty) \implies \exists! w_\lambda,$$

$$\nabla L_\lambda(w_\lambda) = 0 \stackrel{5.1.2}{\iff} \lambda w_\lambda = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} (y - \sigma(\langle w_\lambda, d_{ij} \rangle)) d_{ij},$$

$$|y - \sigma| \leq 1, \quad \|d_{ij}\|_2 \leq 10\sqrt{d} \implies \lambda \|w_\lambda\|_2 \leq \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \|d_{ij}\|_2 \leq 10\sqrt{d}.$$

□

Theorem 5.1.4 (Gradient descent, [9]). *Let $\lambda > 0$, $w^{(0)} \in \mathbb{R}^d$, and $w^{(t+1)} := w^{(t)} - \Lambda^{-1} \nabla L_\lambda(w^{(t)})$. Then for every $t \geq 0$,*

$$L_\lambda(w^{(t)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda) \leq \left(1 - \frac{\lambda}{\Lambda}\right)^t (L_\lambda(w^{(0)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda)),$$

$$\|w^{(t)} - w_\lambda\|_2^2 \leq \frac{2}{\lambda} \left(1 - \frac{\lambda}{\Lambda}\right)^t (L_\lambda(w^{(0)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda)).$$

Proof. Write $f := L_\lambda$, $f^* := f(w_\lambda)$, $g := \nabla f(w^{(t)})$, and apply Lemma A.1.1 with $\mu = \lambda$ and $L = \Lambda$ through Proposition 5.1.3.

$$\nabla^2 f \preceq \Lambda I \stackrel{A.1.1}{\implies} f(w^{(t+1)}) \leq f(w^{(t)}) - \frac{1}{2\Lambda} \|g\|_2^2, \quad \lambda I \preceq \nabla^2 f \stackrel{A.1.1}{\implies} \|g\|_2^2 \geq 2\lambda (f(w^{(t)}) - f^*),$$

$$f(w^{(t+1)}) - f^* \leq \left(1 - \frac{\lambda}{\Lambda}\right) (f(w^{(t)}) - f^*) \implies f(w^{(t)}) - f^* \leq \left(1 - \frac{\lambda}{\Lambda}\right)^t (f(w^{(0)}) - f^*),$$

$$\lambda I \preceq \nabla^2 f \stackrel{A.1.1}{\implies} \frac{\lambda}{2} \|w^{(t)} - w_\lambda\|_2^2 \leq f(w^{(t)}) - f^* \leq \left(1 - \frac{\lambda}{\Lambda}\right)^t (f(w^{(0)}) - f^*).$$

□

Remark 5.1.5 (Optimization in practice). At the scale $d = 21$ and N between 10 and 10^3 , a fixed number of epochs of the update $w^{(t+1)} = w^{(t)} - \eta \nabla L_\lambda(w^{(t)})$ with small λ suffices, each gradient costing $O(Nd)$ operations, since by Theorem 5.1.4

$$\Lambda \leq \lambda + 25d = \lambda + 525, \quad t \geq \frac{\Lambda}{\lambda} \log \frac{L_\lambda(w^{(0)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda)}{\varepsilon} \implies L_\lambda(w^{(t)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda) \leq \varepsilon \quad (\varepsilon > 0).$$

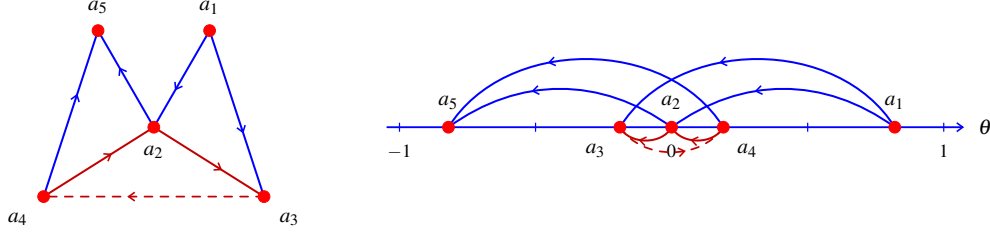


FIGURE 3. Seven comparisons on five applicants: the blue edges $a_1 \rightarrow a_2, a_1 \rightarrow a_3, a_4 \rightarrow a_5, a_2 \rightarrow a_5$ have probabilities .694, .732, .732, .694, the red cycle $a_2 \rightarrow a_3 \rightarrow a_4 \rightarrow a_2$ has probabilities .546, .408, .546 with its violated edge dashed, and the right panel places the same arrows at the $\lambda = .1$ fit $\theta = (.82, 0, -.19, .19, -.82)$.

6. CALIBRATION AND REPORTING

The objective of § 5 determines w through logit differences, so the raw scale of s_w is not intrinsic and applicant-facing reporting uses a monotone calibration to a bounded scale that preserves order [7], [8, Chapter 4]. Throughout, $\mathcal{P} = \{a_1, \dots, a_n\} \subset \mathcal{A}$ is the pool of a session or a reference set, e_c the coordinate vector of $c \in \mathcal{K}$, every submission stores the record $(s_w(a), \hat{s}(a), \text{KW}(a), x(a))$, and a session without a pool file logs $s_w(a)$ and sets the degenerate, non-comparable value $\hat{s}(a) := 10$, so that the whole pipeline of § 3–§ 5 is the composite

$$\mathcal{A} \xrightarrow{x} [0, 10]^{21} \xrightarrow{\langle w_\lambda, \cdot \rangle} \mathbb{R} \xrightarrow{10\hat{F}_{w_\lambda}} \left\{ \frac{10}{n}, \frac{20}{n}, \dots, 10 \right\}.$$

6.1. Percentile calibration and decomposed reporting.

Definition 6.1.1 (Empirical distribution and calibrated score). For $t \in \mathbb{R}$ and $a \in \mathcal{A}$,

$$\hat{F}_w(t) := \frac{1}{n} \sum_{m=1}^n \mathbf{1}\{s_w(a_m) \leq t\}, \quad \hat{s}(a) := 10\hat{F}_w(s_w(a)) = \frac{10}{n} |\{m : s_w(a_m) \leq s_w(a)\}| \in [0, 10].$$

Proposition 6.1.2 (Order preservation and invariance of the calibration). For $a = a_p, b = a_q$ in $\mathcal{P}$, $g : \mathbb{R} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ strictly increasing, $c > 0$, $\hat{F}_{g \circ s_w}$ the empirical distribution of $\{g(s_w(a_m))\}_m$, and $\hat{s}_w$ the calibrated score built from w ,

$$s_w(a) \leq s_w(b) \iff \hat{s}(a) \leq \hat{s}(b), \quad \hat{s}(\mathcal{P}) \subset \left\{ \frac{10}{n}, \dots, 10 \right\}, \quad \max_{\mathcal{P}} \hat{s} = 10,$$

$$\hat{F}_{g \circ s_w} \circ g \circ s_w = \hat{F}_w \circ s_w, \quad \hat{s}_{cw} = \hat{s}_w.$$

Proof. Write $S_p := \{m : s_w(a_m) \leq s_w(a_p)\}$, so that $\hat{s}(a_p) = 10|S_p|/n$ and $p \in S_p$.

$$s_w(a_p) < s_w(a_q) \implies S_p \subsetneq S_q, \quad s_w(a_p) = s_w(a_q) \implies S_p = S_q, \quad s_w(a_p) > s_w(a_q) \implies |S_p| > |S_q|,$$

$$1 \leq |S_p| \leq n, \quad s_w(a_p) = \max_m s_w(a_m) \implies S_p = \{1, \dots, n\}, \quad \{m : g(s_w(a_m)) \leq g(s_w(a_p))\} = S_p,$$

$$s_{cw} = c s_w \xrightarrow{4.1.2} \hat{F}_{cw}(s_{cw}(a_p)) = \hat{F}_{c s_w}(c s_w(a_p)) = \hat{F}_w(s_w(a_p)).$$

□

Remark 6.1.3 (Keyword-only summary). The diagnostic KW of Definition 3.1.4 is the fixed linear functional

$$\text{KW}(a) = \langle u, x(a) \rangle \in [0, 10], \quad u := \frac{1}{4} \sum_{c \in \mathcal{K}} e_c, \quad s_w(a) - \text{KW}(a) = \langle w - u, x(a) \rangle,$$

independent of the learned w and blind to the structured, essay, and penalty blocks, a reviewer-facing meter of resume evidence and not a replacement for s_w .

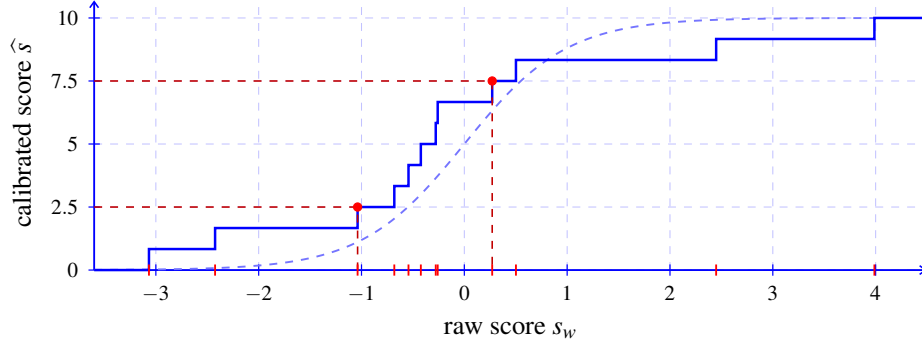


FIGURE 4. Percentile calibration for $n = 12$: the solid staircase $\hat{s} = 10\hat{F}_w(s_w)$ jumps by $10/12$ at the red score marks, the dashed curve is $10\sigma(2s)$, and the red guides give $\hat{s}(b) = 2.5$ at $s_w(b) = -1.038$ and $\hat{s}(a) = 7.5$ at $s_w(a) = .271$.

7. PROOF OF THEOREM A

Theorem 7.0.1 (Regularized pairwise logistic ranking). *Let $x : \mathcal{A} \rightarrow [0, 10]^d$ be a feature map, $\mathcal{D}$ a pairwise dataset, $\lambda > 0$, $\Lambda = \lambda + \frac{1}{4N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \|d_{ij}\|_2^2$, and $\mathcal{P}$ a pool. Then*

- (1) $\lambda I \preceq \nabla^2 L_\lambda(w) \preceq \Lambda I \preceq (\lambda + 25d)I$ for all $w \in \mathbb{R}^d$, and L_λ has a unique minimizer w_λ with $\|w_\lambda\|_2 \leq 10\sqrt{d}/\lambda$.

Proof.

$$0 < \sigma' \leq \frac{1}{4} \xrightarrow{2.1.2, 3.1.9} \|d_{ij}\|_2^2 \leq 100d \xrightarrow{5.1.3} \lambda I \preceq \nabla^2 L_\lambda \preceq \Lambda I \preceq (\lambda + 25d)I, \quad \exists! w_\lambda, \quad \|w_\lambda\|_2 \leq \frac{10\sqrt{d}}{\lambda},$$

□

- (2) w_λ is the unique solution of $\lambda w = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} (y - \sigma(\langle w, d_{ij} \rangle)) d_{ij}$.

Proof.

$$\nabla L_\lambda(w) = 0 \xLeftrightarrow{5.1.2} \lambda w = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} (y - \sigma(\langle w, d_{ij} \rangle)) d_{ij} \xLeftrightarrow{5.1.3} w = w_\lambda,$$

□

- (3) gradient descent with step Λ^{-1} satisfies $L_\lambda(w^{(t)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda) \leq (1 - \lambda/\Lambda)^t (L_\lambda(w^{(0)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda))$.

Proof.

$$w^{(t+1)} = w^{(t)} - \Lambda^{-1} \nabla L_\lambda(w^{(t)}) \xrightarrow{5.1.4} L_\lambda(w^{(t)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda) \leq \left(1 - \frac{\lambda}{\Lambda}\right)^t (L_\lambda(w^{(0)}) - L_\lambda(w_\lambda)),$$

□

- (4) for $a, b \in \mathcal{P}$, $s_w(a) \leq s_w(b) \iff \hat{s}(a) \leq \hat{s}(b)$, and $\hat{s}$ is invariant under $w \mapsto cw$ for $c > 0$.

Proof.

$$a, b \in \mathcal{P} \xrightarrow{6.1.2} (s_w(a) \leq s_w(b) \iff \widehat{s}(a) \leq \widehat{s}(b)), \quad c > 0 \xrightarrow{6.1.2} \widehat{s}_{cw} = \widehat{s}_w.$$

□

8. THE CONJECTURE

The regularization path $\lambda \mapsto w_\lambda$ is the one part of the pipeline whose qualitative behaviour is not settled by § 5–§ 6, and its large- λ limit is the anchor for what follows [8, Chapter 3], [7]. Throughout, $\mathcal{P}$ is a pool, $\mathcal{D}$ a pairwise dataset, $w^* \in \mathbb{R}^d$ a true weight vector, and

$$\bar{d} := \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y) \in \mathcal{D}} (y_{ij} - \tfrac{1}{2}) d_{ij}.$$

8.1. The regularization path and its limit.

Proposition 8.1.1 (Large regularization limit). *For $\lambda > 0$,*

$$\|\lambda w_\lambda - \bar{d}\|_2 \leq (\Lambda - \lambda) \|w_\lambda\|_2 \leq \frac{250d^{3/2}}{\lambda}, \quad \lim_{\lambda \rightarrow \infty} \lambda w_\lambda = \bar{d}.$$

Proof.

$$\nabla L_\lambda(w_\lambda) = 0 \xrightarrow{5.1.2} \lambda w_\lambda - \bar{d} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \left(\tfrac{1}{2} - \sigma(\langle w_\lambda, d_{ij} \rangle) \right) d_{ij}, \quad \sigma(0) = \tfrac{1}{2}, \quad \sigma' \leq \tfrac{1}{4} \xrightarrow{2.1.2} \left| \tfrac{1}{2} - \sigma(t) \right| \leq \tfrac{|t|}{4},$$

$$\|\lambda w_\lambda - \bar{d}\|_2 \leq \frac{1}{4N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} |\langle w_\lambda, d_{ij} \rangle| \|d_{ij}\|_2 \leq \frac{\|w_\lambda\|_2}{4N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \|d_{ij}\|_2^2 = (\Lambda - \lambda) \|w_\lambda\|_2 \xrightarrow{3.1.9, 5.1.3} \frac{25d \cdot 10\sqrt{d}}{\lambda}.$$

□

Conjecture 8.1.2 (Finiteness and stabilization of the path). *For $a, b \in \mathcal{P}$ with $\Delta_{ab}(w_\lambda) \not\equiv 0$, and some $\lambda_0 = \lambda_0(\mathcal{P}, \mathcal{D})$,*

$$|\{\lambda > 0 : \Delta_{ab}(w_\lambda) = 0\}| < \infty, \quad \lambda \geq \lambda_0 \implies (\Delta_{ab}(w_\lambda) < 0 \iff \langle \bar{d}, x(a) - x(b) \rangle < 0).$$

Conjecture 8.1.3 (Sample complexity of the calibrated order). *For labels drawn independently from Remark 2.1.5 with weights w^* on N pairs uniform in $\mathcal{P}$, $|\mathcal{P}| = n$, $\gamma > 0$, and $\lambda \asymp N^{-1/2}$, there are $C, c > 0$ with*

$$N \geq Cd\gamma^{-2} \log n \implies \mathbb{P}(E_\gamma) \geq 1 - n^{-c}, \quad E_\gamma := \bigcap_{|\Delta_{ab}(w^*)| \geq \gamma} \{s_{w^*}(a) < s_{w^*}(b) \iff \widehat{s}(a) < \widehat{s}(b)\}.$$

Conjecture 8.1.4 (Calibration under pool drift). *For pools $\mathcal{P}_0, \mathcal{P}_t$ of sizes n_0, n_t drawn from μ_0, μ_t on $\mathcal{A}$ with $W_1(\mu_0 \circ s_w^{-1}, \mu_t \circ s_w^{-1}) \leq \eta$, and $\widehat{s}^\mathcal{P}$ the calibration of Definition 6.1.1 against $\mathcal{P}$, determine the least $\varepsilon = \varepsilon(\eta, n_0, n_t, \delta)$ and the reference size n_0 with*

$$\mathbb{P}\left(\sup_{a \in \mathcal{A}} |\widehat{s}^{\mathcal{P}_t}(a) - \widehat{s}^{\mathcal{P}_0}(a)| \leq \varepsilon\right) \geq 1 - \delta,$$

replacing the degenerate solo value $\widehat{s}(a) = 10$ of § 6 by a score comparable across sessions.

Part 2. Appendix

APPENDIX A. FOUNDATOIONAL TOOLS

A.1. Quadratic bounds and maximum likelihood.

Lemma A.1.1 (Quadratic bounds from Hessian bounds). *Let $f : \mathbb{R}^d \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ be twice continuously differentiable with $\mu I \preceq \nabla^2 f(w) \preceq LI$ for all w , where $0 < \mu \leq L$, and let w_* be its minimizer. Then for all $v, w \in \mathbb{R}^d$,*

$$\begin{aligned} f(w) + \langle \nabla f(w), v - w \rangle + \frac{\mu}{2} \|v - w\|_2^2 &\leq f(v) \leq f(w) + \langle \nabla f(w), v - w \rangle + \frac{L}{2} \|v - w\|_2^2, \\ \frac{\mu}{2} \|w - w_*\|_2^2 &\leq f(w) - f(w_*) \leq \frac{1}{2\mu} \|\nabla f(w)\|_2^2, \quad f\left(w - \frac{1}{L} \nabla f(w)\right) \leq f(w) - \frac{1}{2L} \|\nabla f(w)\|_2^2. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. Taylor's formula with integral remainder along the segment from w to v gives the first line, and the second follows by choosing v [9, Chapter 3].

$$\begin{aligned} f(v) &= f(w) + \langle \nabla f(w), v - w \rangle + \int_0^1 (1 - \theta) (v - w)^\top \cdot \nabla^2 f(w + \theta(v - w)) \cdot (v - w) d\theta, \\ \int_0^1 (1 - \theta) d\theta &= \frac{1}{2}, \quad \mu \|v - w\|_2^2 \leq (v - w)^\top \cdot \nabla^2 f(w + \theta(v - w)) \cdot (v - w) \leq L \|v - w\|_2^2, \\ v := w - \frac{1}{L} \nabla f(w) &\implies f(v) \leq f(w) - \frac{1}{L} \|\nabla f(w)\|_2^2 + \frac{L}{2} \cdot \frac{1}{L^2} \|\nabla f(w)\|_2^2 = f(w) - \frac{1}{2L} \|\nabla f(w)\|_2^2, \\ v := w_* &\implies f(w_*) \geq f(w) + \min_{u \in \mathbb{R}^d} \left(\langle \nabla f(w), u \rangle + \frac{\mu}{2} \|u\|_2^2 \right) = f(w) - \frac{1}{2\mu} \|\nabla f(w)\|_2^2, \\ w := w_*, \nabla f(w_*) = 0 &\implies f(v) \geq f(w_*) + \frac{\mu}{2} \|v - w_*\|_2^2 \quad (v \in \mathbb{R}^d). \end{aligned}$$

□

Remark A.1.2 (Maximum likelihood and ridge penalty). For conditionally independent labels with $\mathbb{P}(y_{ij} = 1 \mid w) = \sigma(\Delta_{ij}(w))$ and the Gaussian prior $w \sim \mathcal{N}(0, (N\lambda)^{-1}I)$,

$$\begin{aligned} -\frac{1}{N} \log \prod_{(i,j,y)} \sigma(\Delta_{ij}(w))^y (1 - \sigma(\Delta_{ij}(w)))^{1-y} &\xrightarrow{5.1.1} \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \ell_{ij}(w), \\ -\frac{1}{N} \log \exp\left(-\frac{N\lambda}{2} \|w\|_2^2\right) &= \frac{\lambda}{2} \|w\|_2^2, \quad L_\lambda(w) = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{(i,j,y)} \ell_{ij}(w) + \frac{\lambda}{2} \|w\|_2^2, \end{aligned}$$

so w_λ is the maximum-a-posteriori estimate, and w_0 , when $\text{span}\{d_{ij}\} = \mathbb{R}^d$ and the minimum of L_0 is attained, is the maximum-likelihood estimate [8, Chapters 3–4].

APPENDIX B. DATA ARTIFACTS

Three files connect deployed scoring to local training, and the determinism of Definition 3.1.1 is what makes a score computed in the browser reproducible from the stored records.

B.1. Records, pairs, and the model file.

Definition B.1.1 (Artifacts). For a pool $\mathcal{P} = \{a_1, \dots, a_n\}$, a pairwise dataset $\mathcal{D}$, and a weight vector w_λ trained on the schema `fv`,

$$\begin{aligned} \text{applicants.jsonl} &:= \left\{ (m, \text{fv}, x(a_m), s_{w_\lambda}(a_m), \hat{s}(a_m), \text{KW}(a_m)) \right\}_{m=1}^n, \\ \text{pairs.csv} &:= \left\{ (i, j, y_{ij}) \right\}_{(i,j,y) \in \mathcal{D}}, \quad \text{rank_model.json} := (\text{fv}, \lambda, w_\lambda), \end{aligned}$$

one record per applicant, one row per comparison, and one weight vector with the schema it was trained on.

Proposition B.1.2 (Reproducibility of deployed scores). *If the schema of `rank_model.json` equals the schema of the deployed feature map, then for every $a \in \mathcal{P}$ the raw score recomputed at deployment equals the stored one, and the calibrated score and the keyword summary are functions of the stored records alone,*

$$\begin{aligned} \text{fv}_{\text{model}} = \text{fv}_{\text{deploy}} &\implies \langle w_\lambda, x(a) \rangle = s_{w_\lambda}(a), & \text{KW}(a) &= \langle u, x(a) \rangle, \\ \hat{s}(a) &= \frac{10}{n} |\{m : s_{w_\lambda}(a_m) \leq s_{w_\lambda}(a)\}|. \end{aligned}$$

Proof. Definition 3.1.1, Definition 6.1.1, Remark 6.1.3. □

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